

Vim Commands

Vim is modal: keys mean different things depending on the mode. The magic is composition — an operator (`d` , `c` , `y`) plus a motion (`w` , `$` , `}`) acts on exactly that range. Press `Esc` to return to Normal mode any time.

Modes

Key	Enters
<code>Esc</code>	Normal mode (the safe home base)
<code>i</code> / <code>a</code>	Insert before / after the cursor
<code>I</code> / <code>A</code>	Insert at line start / end
<code>o</code> / <code>O</code>	open a new line below / above
<code>v</code> / <code>V</code>	Visual (char) / Visual Line select
<code>Ctrl-v</code>	Visual Block (column) select
<code>:</code>	Command-line mode

Moving Around

Key	Moves to
<code>h j k l</code>	left, down, up, right
<code>w</code> / <code>b</code>	next / previous word start
<code>e</code>	next word end
<code>0</code> / <code>\$</code>	start / end of line
<code>^</code>	first non-blank of line
<code>gg</code> / <code>G</code>	top / bottom of file
<code>{</code> / <code>}</code>	previous / next paragraph
<code>Ctrl-d</code> / <code>Ctrl-u</code>	half-page down / up
<code>%</code>	jump to matching bracket
<code>42G</code>	jump to line 42

Editing

Key	Does
x	delete the character under the cursor
dd / yy	delete / yank (copy) a line
p / P	paste after / before
dw / cw	delete / change to end of word
d\$ / c\$	delete / change to end of line
ciw	change the whole word (inner word)
ci"	change inside the quotes
u / Ctrl-r	undo / redo
.	repeat the last change
>> / <<	indent / outdent a line

Think in sentences. `d2w` = delete two words, `ci(` = change inside parens, `yi{` = yank inside braces. Operator + count + motion composes into thousands of edits you never memorized individually.

Search & Replace

Command	Does
/pattern	search forward (? searches back)
n / N	next / previous match
*	search for the word under the cursor
:%s/old/new/g	replace all in the file
:%s/old/new/gc	replace all, confirm each
:s/old/new/g	replace all on the current line
:noh	clear search highlighting

Files, Windows & Saving

Command	Does
:w	write (save)
:q	quit (fails if unsaved)
:wq or ZZ	save and quit
:q!	quit, discarding changes
:e file	open another file
:sp / :vsp	horizontal / vertical split
Ctrl-w w	cycle between splits
:ls / :b2	list buffers / go to buffer 2

Stuck and can't quit? Press `Esc` first, then type `:q!` and Enter to bail without saving, or `:wq` to save and leave. The `Esc` is what gets you out of Insert mode so the colon command works.